

PUBLIC HEALTH TRIUMPHS THE POLIO STORY...

Polio is a highly infectious disease that primarily affects children under the age of five and can cause paralysis within hours. After Dr. Albert Sabin in 1961 developed a "live" oral vaccine against polio (OPV), it became the vaccine of choice for most national immunization programs in the world. Dr. Albert Sabin then approached Rotary International to use their resources and reach in getting children across the globe immunized against Polio and thus leading the world toward its eventual eradication. In 1985, Rotary International launched PolioPlus, the first and largest internationally coordinated private-sector support of a public health initiative, with an initial pledge of US\$120 million. Inspired in part by Rotary's initiative, the World Health Assembly passes a resolution to eradicate polio, paving the way for the formation of the Global Polio Eradication Initiative in 1988.

The GPEI, spearheaded by National governments, Rotary International, the World Health Organization (WHO), the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) and UNICEF, is the largest public health initiative the world has ever known. Before eradication efforts began in 1988, polio paralyzed more than 1,000 children a day, which totaled about 350,000 children annually. It will be one of the biggest Public Health achievements after mankind eradicated Small Pox through successful immunization.

Rotary International is the largest private sector donor. Till date Rotary has supported more than US \$ 850 million (Rs. 4250 crore) worldwide towards the campaign.

India has been the world's largest polio-endemic country from the very beginning of the polio eradication initiative. Before the introduction of National Immunization Days (NIDs), routine immunization would take care of infants against Polio along with immunization for other diseases. Significant reduction

